

Never Build Alone

A working book brief

September 2026

I am writing Never Build Alone to understand the inheritance that shaped my life, the institutions I tried to build, and the cost of believing that a person can carry a public purpose by himself.

The idea for the book

Never Build Alone is a personal and public book about inheritance, loss, ambition, community, and the search for a different American Dream. It begins with a son trying to understand his father's unfinished life and ends with a question about what it means to build institutions that no single person can own, control, or complete alone.

The book follows my movement across three generations and several worlds: Puerto Rican family life in New York; the South Bronx and public education; the work of my father and grandfather; my own experience as a teacher and builder; entrepreneurial ecosystems; economic development; public institutions; and the effort to create forms of shared ownership and shared prosperity.

The personal story is not an ornament placed around a business or policy argument. It is the way the argument becomes visible. I learned to think about institutions because I was trying to understand a family inheritance. I became interested in schools because I was trying to understand what my father had built and what had been left unfinished. I became interested in entrepreneurship and economic development because I wanted to know whether communities could create opportunity without losing their relationships, dignity, or control.

The book's central tension is that I wanted to serve a public purpose, but I often carried that purpose through individual effort, private sacrifice, and personal identification with the work. I believed in community, but I repeatedly found myself alone inside the institutions I was trying to build. I wanted to create shared prosperity, but I struggled with my own sense of worth. When you feel like you do not matter, you can write yourself out of the story: undervalue your contribution, fail to negotiate for the pay you deserve, allow other people to take your accomplishments as their own, or accept responsibility for work that no one else is willing to carry. It can become difficult to understand where my contribution begins and ends, and where someone else's begins and ends.

The title is both a warning and a discovery. I spent years trying to build things as if the right idea, the right structure, or the right amount of effort could overcome the need for deeper interdependence. The work taught me the opposite. No meaningful institution is built by one person. But many institutions are built around the mythology of one person, and that mythology eventually becomes a source of fragility.

The book asks what happens when a private wound becomes a public vocation, and what it costs when I confuse being needed with being valued. It asks what happens when a vocation creates institutions that reproduce the same isolation the work was meant to overcome.

Inheritance, exile, and return

The emotional structure of the book is a movement from inheritance to exile to return.

Inheritance is not only what I received. It is also what I did not understand. My father became a figure whose work, ideals, wounds, and unfinished responsibilities remained present even after his death. My grandfather's migration and labor formed another layer of the family story. The institutions my father believed in gave me a vocabulary for service, education, and public life, but they also left questions about sacrifice, recognition, and what a person owes to the people who come after him.

Exile describes the period in which I tried to make a life and a contribution outside the original frame. I moved through teaching, entrepreneurship, organizational work, economic development, and the building of new institutions. I experienced real success and real belonging, but I also became separated from the people and places I thought I was serving. The farther I moved into professional and institutional life, the more I had to ask whether I was building community or merely building a role for myself inside the language of community.

Return is not a simple homecoming. It is the attempt to see the past without being governed by it. It means returning to family history, to public education, to the Bronx, to the question of ownership, and to the institutions that formed me. It also means returning to the work after the brain hemorrhage, conflict, failure, and separation, with less certainty about what one person can accomplish and a clearer understanding of what must be shared.

The public work enters through these stages. The family story creates the questions. Education gives them a social setting. Entrepreneurship gives them an economic setting. Institutional work gives them consequences. The book becomes a memoir of how a person tries to turn inheritance into public usefulness without writing himself out of the story - without undervaluing his contribution, taking on more responsibility than he should, or allowing the work to consume the person doing it.

The opportunity

The opportunity is to tell a personal story that makes institutional and economic questions emotionally legible.

Many books about economic change begin with systems, statistics, or policy. Many memoirs begin with family and remain inside the private self. *Never Build Alone* can move between those worlds. It can show how family history becomes a theory of institutions, how institutions shape identity, and how economic arrangements enter intimate life.

The book would speak to people who sense that something is broken in the American promise but do not want another abstract critique. It would speak to educators, founders, community leaders, nonprofit professionals, and readers of narrative nonfiction who are trying to reconcile personal responsibility with structural reality.

The book's opportunity is not to present me as a model founder or a perfected public intellectual. It is to tell the truth about the emotional and institutional costs of building in public. It can show that community work is not only about good intentions. It involves power, money, ownership, governance, recognition, exhaustion, conflict, and the difficult question of who gets to decide what a shared institution becomes.

The story of ESO Ventures gives the book a public scale. A small East Oakland project became a company, a fund, a network, and an institution entrusted with substantial resources. The founders brought different histories, forms of knowledge, relationships, and visions. They built something that created real value. They also placed multiple purposes inside a single vessel without fully deciding how those purposes would be governed or measured.

That institutional story matters because it is not simply a company story. It is a story about what happens when community need, public money, private ownership, founder identity, and economic aspiration meet inside one organization. The company became a test of whether social capital can be converted into lasting public

infrastructure without being exhausted, captured, or left dependent on the people who first assembled it.

The personal story gives the institutional story stakes. I was not studying the problem from a distance. I was implicated in it. I helped create the vessel, carried relationships into it, depended on it, benefited from it, and was hurt by its limits. The brain hemorrhage exposed how much of the work existed inside people rather than systems. The later conflict exposed how much trust had been asked to do the work of governance. The attempted separation exposed unresolved questions about contribution, authorship, ownership, and responsibility.

That is the opportunity of the book: to make the invisible dimensions of institution-building visible without turning the story into an audit, a corporate celebration, or a postmortem.

Why me

I am uniquely positioned to write this book because I am both the narrator and one of the people inside the problem.

I carry a family history shaped by migration, education, public service, and unfinished work. I have spent my adult life trying to understand what I inherited and what I am responsible for continuing. My relationship to institutions is therefore personal before it is theoretical.

I have also moved through the actual worlds the book wants to connect. I have taught. I have worked with young people and schools. I have built entrepreneurial programs and economic-development initiatives. I have worked with public agencies, colleges, funders, founders, boards, and community organizations. I have seen how ideas change when they encounter contracts, budgets, hiring, governance, and the daily needs of an institution.

I understand the seduction of building. A new institution can feel like proof that relationships, imagination, and effort can overcome inherited limits. It can create a temporary world in which people see one another differently and believe a better arrangement is possible. I also understand how quickly that promise becomes a burden when the institution expands faster than its constitution, when founders become symbols, and when personal loyalty substitutes for clear authority.

My authority comes from participation, not distance. I have made mistakes. I have overidentified with the work. I have asked institutions to carry emotional and moral responsibilities that should have been shared more deliberately. The brain hemorrhage I suffered in April 2022, in the middle of ESO's growth phase, is one example of what I want to explore: the human fragility, cost, and sacrifice that often accompany efforts to change systems. I have also been part of conflicts in which the questions were not only financial or strategic, but also about trust, recognition, belonging, and the meaning of contribution.

That complexity is not a weakness of the story. It is the reason to tell it.

I can write about public purpose without pretending to be outside ambition. I can write about shared ownership without pretending that ownership is emotionally simple. I can write about community without flattening conflict. I can write about institutional failure without erasing the real value that institutions create.

I am also uniquely positioned to connect the intimate and the structural. A father's death can open questions about education, inheritance, and responsibility. The brain hemorrhage I suffered in April 2022, in the middle of ESO's growth phase, reveals the human fragility, cost, and sacrifice that often accompany efforts to change systems. The later conflict between the founders exposed the gap between relational trust and the importance of clear governance and structures. A company can become a mirror for the question that began in the family: What do we owe one another, and what kind of structure can carry that obligation after we are gone?

Why now

I am writing this book now because I have reached the point at which the past can no longer remain a collection of separate stories.

The family story, the educational work, the entrepreneurial work, the creation of ESO, the formation of SPCC.1, the development of Covenant OS, the experience of the brain hemorrhage I suffered in April 2022, and the struggle over institutional direction are not separate chapters of my life. They are different expressions of one question: How can a person turn inheritance into shared capacity without reproducing isolation and control?

The timing also matters because many people are trying to build institutions in conditions that resemble the ones I encountered: large public needs, ambitious founders, strained systems, new forms of capital, urgent social problems, and an intense desire to create something that matters. The culture often celebrates the founder while underinvesting in the relationships, governance, and connective labor that make institutions sustainable.

We are surrounded by stories of individual brilliance. We need more honest stories about interdependence.

The current moment also makes the question of the American Dream unavoidable. The promise of individual advancement has not disappeared, but it has become increasingly difficult to separate from the systems that make advancement possible. Education, housing, capital, healthcare, family support, public infrastructure, and social networks all shape what appears to be individual success.

My life has moved through that contradiction. I have been encouraged to build my own future while being formed by institutions and relationships that I did not create. I have wanted independence while depending on community. I have wanted to create shared prosperity while still carrying the habits of individual achievement. The book is an attempt to tell the truth about that contradiction rather than resolve it too quickly.

What I really want to do

What I really want to do is understand the relationship between the life I inherited and the institutions I tried to build.

I want to tell the story of my father and grandfather without turning them into symbols. I want to show the people they were, the worlds they inhabited, the limits they carried, and the unfinished work they left behind.

I want to show how a person can spend years trying to redeem an inheritance without fully knowing what redemption would look like. I want to examine the ways ambition can be a form of love, the ways service can become a form of avoidance, and the ways public work can conceal private loneliness.

I want to document the building of institutions as a human process. That means including the moments of excitement and possibility, but also the underpaid labor, the confusion, the weak structures, the misread relationships, the governance gaps, the physical limits, and the questions that success does not answer.

I want the reader to see that an institution can create real value and still remain unfinished. ESO did not fail simply because it encountered conflict, nor did it succeed simply because it attracted money and produced results. Its meaning lies in the tension between what it made possible and what it was not yet structured to sustain.

I want the book to become an argument for a more mature understanding of building. Building is not only starting something. It is creating the conditions for something to continue without depending on one person's charisma, sacrifice, or control. It is compensating connective labor. It is separating purposes clearly enough to

govern them. It is making room for other people to own, alter, and complete what began with you.

The book should not end by presenting a perfect institution. It should end with a more honest definition of shared prosperity: not only more resources, but more agency, more capacity, more knowledge, more durable relationships, and more people able to participate in decisions that affect their lives.

The personal story and the public question

The book's deepest movement is from a private question to a public one.

At first, I am trying to understand my father. Then I am trying to understand the institutions that shaped him and me. Then I am trying to build institutions that might carry the values I inherited. Finally, I have to ask whether those institutions are actually capable of carrying those values beyond the people who created them.

That is where the personal story bumps against the public. A family can survive on love, memory, loyalty, and improvisation. An institution needs those things, but it also needs structure, authority, accountability, renewal, and the ability to make responsibility visible. What is beautiful in a family can become dangerous in an organization if it remains unspoken. What feels like trust can become dependency. What feels like sacrifice can become a claim on other people's lives.

The book is therefore not only about what happened to me. It is about what happens when people try to convert personal conviction into public form.

I want readers to feel the intimacy of the story and still see the larger systems around it. I want them to understand that institutional questions are never only technical. They are shaped by memory, identity, grief, pride, fear, hope, and the desire to matter.

The final insight is simple: we do not build alone, even when we believe we are alone. We inherit language, relationships, institutions, wounds, and possibilities from people who came before us. We build through networks we did not create. We depend on work from those whose names may never appear in the founding story. We create futures that other people will have to govern.

Never Build Alone is my attempt to understand that inheritance and to become more responsible for what I pass forward.